

"Public good is important but not at the cost of national security."

SHASHANK, FORMER FOREIGN SECRETARY

Ministry of Information Technology whose affiliated body National Informatics Centre (NIC) currently manages the passport issuance system and manages PISON (passport information service system on the net). Sources in security agencies say checking indexes and blacklists is a secret exercise performed by government officials which requires certain expertise and subjec-

use of data and says, "All sensitive aspects of passport issuance, including verification of documents, check-lists and final grant order will remain with the government officials. The aim is to issue a passport within three days".

Diplomatic sources say globally such exercise is not conducted in the manner proposed in the consultant's report that was commissioned by the

passport work. But under the fresh proposal, it is not clear as to who will take the blame, in case the private vendor makes a mistake. "There has to be a system of checks and balances, and accountability needs to be fixed. While public convenience is important, it should not be at the cost of national security," feels former foreign secretary Shashank, who has also served as a chief passport officer.

QAMAR SIBTAIN



NEW DILEMMA: The regional passport office at Delhi's Bhikaji Cama Place

tive decisions in case of security alerts. Moreover, it is performed in a secured location and if left at the facilitation centre, it can be compromised due to its proximity to the applicants.

What is equally intriguing is that there is a great deal of secrecy around the project which is being directly monitored by a key aide of External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee. "We have just been told that the project needs to be pushed at all costs, although there are doubts about its workability," remarked a passport official. Insiders say that both the junior ministers, Anand Sharma and E. Ahamed, who also happen to overlook the passport division, have been kept out of the loop. The silence maintained by the ministry was also intriguing. However, Sharad Sabharwal, additional secretary in the MEA, allays fears of mis-

foreign office, and in most of the western nations passport issuance system stays with government agencies. The fact that the passport database will be shared with private vendors has also been objected to by security agencies who had voiced concern at an inter-ministerial meeting held in Hyderabad last year to discuss the new passport project. Another big loophole in the proposal seems to be development of a new software which would mean that the private software developer, that includes some foreign companies as well will have access to the entire database and the key to the new Indian passport system, which may be subjected to a breach. Also under the Passports Act, passed by Parliament, accountability is fixed with MEA officials who normally handle

Interestingly, in 1985, when a proposal was made to switch the passport issuance system from the Ministry of External Affairs to the Ministry of Home Affairs, it was promptly shot down by the then prime minister Rajiv Gandhi, and now it seems the UPA Government wants to move away from it. When the Government already has a secure system designed by its agency, the easiest thing would have been to upgrade the software than do it afresh. And if the real objective was to ensure convenience of passport seekers, more application centres could have been opened to reduce the delay. Currently, there are 33 regional passport offices, besides 15 collection centres that are manned by the police and the district administrations.

Officials say NIC has built a lot of services both at the regional passport offices and at the central locations, and the big challenge will also be their compatibility with the proposed new software. Also, it is not clear as to who will be responsible for generation of objection letters, granting of passports, printing and lamination besides the dispatch of the passport document. While the Government is planning to pay productivity-linked incentives not exceeding 1.46 per cent of the revenue generated to the Central Passport Organisation employees as a sop, this may open a Pandora's box, with other government departments also pitching for such an incentive.

While the jury may be out on why the Government is keen on pushing forward a major project in the last year of its term, without assessing its impact on the passport issuance system, for now it is a big mess.